

Can Russellian Monism Accommodate Modal Recombination?

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Abstract: Russellian Monism has grown in popularity in recent years, promising to provide an elegant theory of the mind by identifying phenomenality with the intrinsic. In addition, some Russellian Monists think that such an intrinsic nature grounds the structural properties of an entity. However, as an independent metaphysical principle, we have strong reasons to be skeptical of theories that posit necessary connections between discontinuous properties. I argue that Russellian Monism is ultimately committed to the existence of metaphysically discontinuous properties, and is thus in tension with this principle. Furthermore, I argue that this cannot be reconciled by appealing to an essentialist explanation. I thereby conclude that we should think of Russellian Monism as an implausible theory of consciousness.

1. Introduction

At the core of the mind-body problem is the question of how experientiality can arise in a seemingly non-experiential universe. On one end of the spectrum, if we accept dualism, it seems difficult to reconcile the plausible empirical fact that the universe is physically causally closed with the everyday observation that our conscious experiences are at least somewhat causally efficacious. On the other end of the spectrum, physicalists have no challenge explaining the causal efficacy of the mental, for if mental states just are physical states, they are thus subsumed under physical causal closure. The challenge for physicalism, then, is to provide an account of how mental states are either identical to or are reducible to physical ones. But as many have clarified this challenge over the last few decades, the hope that physicalism could provide such an account has dwindled.¹

In light of the difficulties both dualism and physicalism have faced in reconciling these intuitions while maintaining realism about the mind, Russellian Monism has grown in popularity, allowing its proponents to maintain an unshakable conviction in the existence of conscious experience by denying the explanatory reach of physics to extend to all concretely real phenomena in our universe. In positing the silence of physics on the intrinsic natures of individuals, the Russellian Monist can then identify the place of consciousness in an otherwise physical world. And as a result of integrating phenomenality into the physical, Russellian Monism also provides an account of phenomenal causal efficacy by subsuming mental events under the physical events they ground, and thus under the relata of physical causal relations. Therefore, it seems Russellian Monism promises to provide an account of consciousness that, in a sense, lets us have our cake and eat it too.

Though different theorists will maintain different commitment when it comes to consciousness, I take all those who would consider themselves Russellian Monists to be committed to the following core theses, as described by Ney (2015):

- 1) Physical Structuralism: Physics describes its most fundamental features only relationally.
- 2) The Structure-Grounding Thesis: There must be some account of fundamental intrinsic features to supplement or support the relational description of physics (of (1)).

¹ See Jackson (1986), Chalmers (1996), Block (1978), Levine (1983), Searle (1980), Nagel (1974)

- 3) The Phenomenal Intrinsicity Thesis: There exist intrinsic, phenomenal features that constitute the natures of our conscious experiences.
- 4) The Phenomenal-Grounding Thesis: Either these intrinsic, phenomenal features (of (3)) are fundamental, or there must be more fundamental, intrinsic features on which they depend.
- 5) The Unification Thesis: The structure-grounding intrinsic features (of (2)) are identical to the phenomenal-grounding intrinsic features (of (4)).

By accepting thesis 2 above, Russellian Monism is committed to what I will call structure-quality supervenience: for any entity *e* that instantiates a qualitatively-based structural property *S* at *t*, there necessarily exists a categorical ground *G* such that *e* instantiates *G* at *t*, and necessarily anything instantiating *G* at any time instantiates *S* at that time. Put more succinctly, if any two metaphysically possible entities are identical in all qualitatively-based structural respects, they must be alike in all categorical respects as well.² Strawson (2017), one of the more prominent defenders of Russellian Monism today, explicitly endorses this thesis, writing:

“For then a full description of *x*’s structural/role nature and overall behavioural-dispositional being, which is still wholly grounded, as it must be, in its categorical/quiddital nature, will include a description of its disposition to behave in way *A* in nomic environment 1, a description of its disposition to behave in way *B* in nomic environment 2, and so on. So its fundamental structural/role nature—its overall behavioural-dispositional being—will remain as invariant as its categorical/quiddital nature.”³

And although the truth of such a thesis would serve to provide an elegant and well-integrated theory of the mind, my goal here will be to argue that structure-quality supervenience is ultimately in tension with The Phenomenal Intrinsicity Thesis. In particular, I will argue that the supervenience relationship between the phenomenal and the structural under Russellian Monism is unintelligible if they are discontinuous properties. Additionally, I suggest reasons why I think the Russellian Monist cannot defer to essentialist explanations in order to accommodate for structure-quality supervenience.

2. The Intuitive Challenge

By identifying the intrinsic, phenomenal features that constitute the nature of conscious experiences with the categorical grounds of the relational description of physics, the Russellian Monist is left with a certain modal challenge: how can we explain the supervenience of structural properties as described by physics on the intrinsic, phenomenal features that constitute the natures of conscious experiences if, as Strawson (2006) says, “The experiential/non-experiential divide, assuming that it exists at all, is the most fundamental divide in nature.” Borrowing from McPherson and Plunkett (2025) and their work in metaethics, the challenge can be clarified as follows:

² Contrary to what the name says, I think it is best to interpret The Structure-Grounding Thesis as one of supervenience instead of grounding here. This is because, while both relations are explanatorily sufficient for the purposes of the Russellian Monist to “supplement or support the relational description of physics”, supervenience commits one to less since it doesn’t incur the burden of explaining why the relationship between structure and quality is constitutive in nature. Indeed, given anti-emergent considerations, it seems just as implausible for physical properties to emerge from phenomenal ones as phenomenal properties emerging from physical ones. Nevertheless, those who disagree with this interpretation may read the following arguments as conditional on if structure supervenes on quality instead of being grounded in it.

³ And within contemporary analytic metaphysics, other notable theorists who have endorsed this thesis include Lewis (1986), Martin & Heil (1999), and Schaffer (2009).

Brute Connection: The Russellian Monist must take the supervenience of the qualitatively-based structural properties of an entity on its categorical properties to involve a brute necessary connection between discontinuous properties.⁴

Generalized Modest Humean: It counts significantly against a theory if it posits a brute fact that rules out the free recombination of discontinuous properties across the space of metaphysically possible worlds.

Let us take some time to briefly unpack these claims. First, note Brute Connection's mention of discontinuous properties. Following Bengson, Cuneo, and Shafer-Landau (2024), I propose we should understand metaphysical discontinuity as "the absence of metaphysical continuity, where what it is for A to be metaphysically continuous with B is either for A to be identical to B or for there to be a suitably specific metaphysically respectable category C (e.g., *being natural*) such that A and B both essentially belong to C." I take this to capture one of the core commitments of the Russellian Monist, as quoted from Strawson above: that mentality is just too different from any property posited by physics for the experiential to either emerge from or be reduced to the physical. Second, Brute Connection concerns itself with brute necessary connections. I take a brute connection to be a type of connection where a demand for explanation is appropriate but nevertheless lacks a satisfactory explanation. We can contrast this type of connection with two other types of connections: 1, connections that can be adequately explained, and 2, connections where a demand for explanation is inappropriate.

Against Brute Connection, the Russellian Monist might object on two fronts: for one, they may suggest that categorical properties are already structural in part—the instantiation of some categorical properties is sufficient for the instantiation of certain structural properties. This is because we should think of categorical properties as intrinsically powerful in some way, disposed to behave in certain nomic environments *in virtue* of how it is. And two, as conceptual diagnosis, the Russellian Monist may assert that the supposed radical difference between experiential and non-experiential is epistemic rather than ontological. Physics, under the Russellian Monist position, does not posit any intrinsic qualities—its descriptions are entirely structural and mathematical. The gap between phenomenal and physical, then, might simply be an illusion.

These objections, as I take it, are plausibly true. However, I do not think they in any sense undermine the thesis I am trying to advance. Instead, they might serve to clarify what I mean by metaphysical discontinuity. Against the first line of objection, I want to stress that the mere fact that categorical properties are capable of manifesting certain structural properties, even necessarily under certain nomic environments, does not mean they fall under the same metaphysical kind as said structural properties. To make this point more salient, imagine a world in which ethical supervenience holds and

⁴ Note, I am only focusing on a specific subset of structural properties—those that are central to physics' causal/explanatory framework (mass, charge, spin, etc.). For clarity, I will refer to this subset of structural properties as qualitatively-based structural properties, in contrast to abstract, mathematical structural properties that obtain as a result of relations between entities. I take it that these qualitatively-based structural properties are the ones that the Russellian Monist identifies as supervening upon phenomenal, categorical qualities. My argument going forward concerns the intelligibility of this supervenience relation between this specific subset of structural properties and its supervenient base and whether it can be made non-brute, given a metaphysical discontinuity between quality and structure.

non-naturalism about moral properties were true: the instantiation of normative properties wholly depends on the instantiation of non-normative ones, and we can say that these normative properties are instantiated in virtue of how the world is like; the descriptive facts are, in some sense, powerful. Yet, by stipulation, these normative and non-normative properties do not fall under the same metaphysical kind. Note, this alone does not show that the intrinsic, phenomenal properties posited by Russellian Monism are metaphysically discontinuous with physical properties, but it does serve to demonstrate that ontological dependency does not entail sameness of metaphysical kind.

Furthermore, I want to point out that Brute Connection acknowledges and accepts that physics, as understood by the Russellian Monist, does not ascribe intrinsic non-structural stuff-constituting properties at all. Yet it would be fallacious to take this silence to mean that there is, in fact, no problematic radical difference. The point of Brute Connection is to highlight that this silence is ontologically significant. If physics only describes relational roles, and if phenomenal qualities cannot be reduced to such roles, then positing a phenomenal intrinsic base constitutes an addition to the physical story, not a completion. Regardless of whether or not physics posits intrinsic natures, phenomenal qualities do have a categorical character, and thus are essentially unlike mathematical structure.

Now, we turn to Generalized Modest Humean. An epistemological cousin of Hume's dictum, Generalized Modest Humean does not deny that there can be necessary connections between distinct entities, and instead only says that it is a theoretical vice for any theory to prohibit the free recombination of metaphysically discontinuous properties across modal space without providing an explanation as to *why* their recombination should be prohibited. This is because, when we consider paradigmatic examples of discontinuous properties, we should think those properties are able to recombine across different possible worlds. Take, for example, the properties of being a triangle and being blue. When I examine the vast array of all metaphysically possible worlds, I would expect that every combination of the presence or absence of blueness or triangularity to be instantiated in some possible world. Intuitively, a theory that prohibits this modal recombination from occurring without providing an explanation as to why discontinuous properties cannot recombine suffers a theoretical vice. And so, if we stipulate that, say, phenomenal redness grounds negative charge, in accordance with structure-quality supervenience, the Russellian Monist must take it as an unexplained fact that there can be no possible world in which phenomenal redness is instantiated without negative charge also being instantiated, and vice versa.⁵ This seems deeply counterintuitive in much the same way that saying redness grounds triangularity seems counterintuitive. Note, however, that Generalized Modest Humean does not deny the possibility of brute contingencies when attempting to explain the physical world (e.g., it is just a brute fact that the fundamental constants just so happened to be the values they are). By contrast, because the modal scope of structure-quality supervenience extends to different possible worlds, the Russellian Monist should not accept the proposal that it is a brute contingent fact that the relational properties of an entity just so happen to covary with its categorical grounds.

⁵ Furthermore, it seems to me that appealing to phenomenologically robust experiences, such as that of pain, does little to help explain the relationship between quality and structure. This is because the relationship between my macro-level conscious states, such as pain, and my physical behavior, such as flinching, is causal, while the relationship between some phenomenal supervenient base and the structure that supervenes upon it is modal. Cases of causal explanation are disanalogous to those of modal determination, and we should not think that our macro-level experiences can be generalized to a modal relation at the fundamental level.

Taken together, Brute Connection and Generalized Modest Humean entail the truth of structure-quality supervenience counts against the Russellian Monist. But, it may be pointed out immediately that Russellian Monism actually *does* have an explanation for structure-quality supervenience: the experiential, intrinsic nature of entities *grounds* its relational properties. And indeed, this is what the core theses of Russellian Monism say.⁶ Under the assumption that the grounding relation entails necessary connections, it seems that the Russellian Monist's commitment to grounding is well suited to explain structure-quality supervenience. But the appeal to grounding has not yet pulled the Russellian Monist out of the Humean rabbit hole, for the grounding relationship itself calls out for explanation. If grounding itself were a brute fact, then its explanation of structure-quality supervenience would do no favors for the Russellian Monist; it has merely moved the explanatory bump in the carpet, so to speak.

3. Can Standard Russellian Monism Explain Supervenience

So what would it take for the Russellian Monist to provide a satisfactory account of structure-quality supervenience that does not appeal to any objectionably brute facts? For one, the Russellian Monist could just deny that the intrinsic, phenomenal properties of entities are in fact deeply metaphysically discontinuous with the relational, physical properties of those entities. Remember, as stipulated above, properties are metaphysically continuous if and only if they are either identical to one another or if they fall under the same metaphysically respectable category. Strawson (2006), endorsing a commitment to what he calls “real” physicalism, identifies the intrinsic, experiential nature of entities as truly physical properties. However, simply calling these properties “physical” seems to be misleading, for there is no explanation as to *why* we should think the kinds of properties found within the intrinsic nature of entities fall within the same metaphysical category as the properties postulated by physics.⁷ In fact, the supposed radical difference between mind and body should provide us with some reason for thinking the intrinsic, experiential nature of entities that constitutes our phenomenal consciousness is also radically different from the properties postulated by our best physics. To discriminate between these types of properties, I will call the relational properties as postulated by physics *physical_r*, and I will call the intrinsic properties of entities *physical_i*. An argument for the metaphysical discontinuity of *physical_i* and *physical_r* can be made as follows, following considerations from anti-emergence:

1. Emergence is a relation where the emergence of a higher-order property Y from a lower-order property X can only be the case if Y is wholly dependent on X and X alone.
2. If experientiality is radically different from non-experientiality, then it cannot be wholly dependent on *physical_r* alone.
3. Therefore, experientiality cannot emerge from *physical_r* alone.
4. Experientiality can emerge from *physical_i* if *physical_i* already contains an experiential character.

⁶ It is an open question, I think, whether the intrinsic, experiential properties of entities fully grounds or only partially grounds the entity's relational properties. For sake of argument, whenever I say that *x* grounds *y*, I will mean that *x* *fully* grounds *y*. In light of this, my argument should be read as a conditional: *if* the intrinsic, experiential nature of entities fully grounds its relational properties, then Russellian Monism has a challenge in explaining structure-quality supervenience.

⁷ Given Physical Structuralism, this may seem to miss the point. If physics fails to attribute qualities, it's obvious that such qualities will differ in some significant way from the properties postulated by physics. But the silence of physics is a *datum*, not a solution. We cannot infer whether or not such qualities are metaphysically continuous or not with physical properties from Physical Structuralism alone—it must be established on independent grounds.

5. If two properties cannot play the same grounding role with respect to a certain target phenomenon, then we should think those properties to be different in kind.
6. Therefore, *physical_i* and *physical_r* differ in kind.
7. Therefore, *physical_r* and *physical_i* are metaphysically discontinuous properties.

This line of reasoning follows roughly from what Strawson (2006) has already argued: only properties that already contain some element of experientiality can ground phenomenal consciousness without appealing to brute emergence. He makes the point as follows, writing:

“If it really is true that Y is emergent from X then it must be the case that Y is in some sense wholly dependent on *X and X alone*, so that all features of Y trace intelligibly back to x (where ‘intelligible’ is a metaphysical rather than an epistemic notion). Emergence can’t be brute. It is built into the heart of the notion of emergence that emergence cannot be brute in the sense of there being absolutely no reason in the nature of things why the emerging thing is as it is (so that it is unintelligible even to God). For any feature Y of anything that is correctly considered to be emergent from X, *there must be something about X and X alone in virtue of which Y emerges, and which is sufficient for Y.*” (emphasis mine)

But *physical_r* lacks any experiential character by definition—it consists solely of the relational, structural properties posited by physics. On the other hand, we have at least some positive reason to think that *physical_i* can include experientiality, or at the very least we cannot rule out its possibility. So, if only *physical_i* can plausibly serve as a ground for phenomenal consciousness, then *physical_i* and *physical_r* must differ in their essential grounding capacities with respect to phenomenal consciousness. And if two categories of properties differ in their essential grounding capacities, they must also differ in metaphysical kind. Note here that I take metaphysical kindhood to be tied to some property’s *grounding capacities* within our ontology, such that individuals that cannot enter into a grounding relation with some target phenomena are metaphysically discontinuous from those individuals that can enter into said grounding relation.⁸

Therefore, if *physical_r* and *physical_i* are defined in part by what they can ground, as the Russellian Monist wants to say—i.e., if *physical_r* is essentially non-experiential and *physical_i* is essentially experiential—then they’re playing fundamentally different roles in the ontological structure of reality and thus cannot fall under the same kind without thereby trivializing the notion of kind. These are not just two instances of one kind of thing doing different things; they are ontologically distinct categories in that they function differently in the sorts of phenomena that they can realize. Thus, unless the Russellian Monist can show that *physical_r* and *physical_i* are unified in terms of their grounding capacities, or otherwise show that they are both realized by a deeper metaphysical kind, simply putting them under the same kind by calling them both “physical” erases the crucial distinction between the natures and explanatory roles of *physical_r* and *physical_i*.

⁸ Here, I assume the grounding relation is kind-dependent, such that: 1) grounding relations are reducible to claims about essences, or at least intimately tied with them; and 2) an individual’s fundamental kind can determine the sorts of grounding relations it can enter into. Thus, to differ in grounding capacities just is to differ in metaphysical kind. See Fine (2015) and Moran (2018) for defenses of this line of reasoning.

As I have argued, Russellian Monism cannot claim that *physical_i* properties fall under the same metaphysical kind as *physical_r* properties due to a difference in their essential grounding capacities, even if *physical_r* properties necessarily covary with their *physical_i* properties.

However, as a response to this objection, the Russellian Monist might simply say that there are no such things as *physical_r* properties as something ontologically distinct from *physical_i* properties. Instead, they could just claim that the difference between quality and structure is descriptive rather than ontological, thereby maintaining continuity between *physical_r* and *physical_i* properties. As Howell (2015) puts it:

“This might not be the best way of putting things, however. Perhaps it is more accurate to say that there are not two different properties here. There is one property—the phenomenal property—that endows its bearer with certain dispositions because of the physical laws that govern it. Suppose R is the categorical property of phenomenal redness and this is the ground of negative charge. On the 'identity' construal, it is not that there is a property R and a dispositional property D and R grounds D. It is rather that there is a property R and a law that states that things with R repel one another, etc. There is one [categorical phenomenal] property, and talk of a dispositional property is just a way of characterizing the way the law governs that [categorical phenomenal] property in relation to other properties”

The dispositional nature of some entity, under this view, is thus not grounded in its intrinsic nature, but instead is simply how such an intrinsic nature behaves under certain laws. However, like the above response from the Russellian Monist to save metaphysical continuity, we should not think that this identity response provides a satisfactory dissolution of the structure-quality discontinuity as it appears in nature. Instead, it only relabels the problem and asserts continuity instead of providing an explanation for it. There are a few reasons, I think, that make this move unattractive for the Russellian Monist. One, if we accept Humeanism about the laws of nature, simply saying that laws provide a source of unity between quality and structure fails to provide an explanation as to *why* quality behaves in the way that it does. Laws on this view are not intrinsic features of categorical properties—they are merely external, modal generalizations about what happens when said categorical property is instantiated in the world. Laws, therefore, cannot provide us with an explanation as to *how* some categorical property behaves in some way specified by its dispositional role; laws can tell us *what* happens, not *why* it happens. And if we accept some form of non-Humeanism, then the Russellian Monist faces the challenge of explaining why the relevant modal connections hold between quality and structure. Even if one does not think of laws as ontologically over-and-above the nature of things, but instead as expressive of their intrinsic dispositional essence, the question remains: why does a given categorical property have the particular dispositional profile it does, rather than some other? Whether one treats laws as independent governing principles or as embedded in the very nature of the categorical base, the explanatory task is the same—namely, to show how it is that phenomenal quality yields its associated structural-relational profile. Without such an account, the connection between quality and structure appears brute. This does not strike me as a favorable alternative to the brute identity claim.

Additionally, there seems to be an asymmetry in intelligibility between categorical grounds and dispositional roles. It seems easy to conceive of a world in which basic categorical grounds manifest under certain environments as dispositional roles, where the structure of this world is to be understood as

an expression of its underlying quality. Indeed, this is just what structure-quality supervenience says. The reverse, however, does not seem as easily conceivable: how can structure alone give rise to any specific quality without invoking some brute metaphysically necessary connection between them? I do not take this asymmetry to be a knockdown argument of this identity proposal, but it certainly requires the Russellian Monist to provide reasons for thinking there is in fact symmetry. By erasing the distinction between structure and quality as ontologically distinct properties through this identity proposal, it seems to me that, without some intelligible mechanism provided to explain how dispositional roles arise out of categorical grounds, the retreat from a grounding relationship between quality and structure into an identity one does nothing to help explain how *physical_r* and *physical_i* are metaphysically continuous.

In short, the identity proposal does no favors for the Russellian Monist. If the dispositional profile of matter is not intelligibly necessitated by its categorical grounds, then the identity claim is hollow. And if it is intelligibly necessitated, then the Russellian Monist owes us a non-brute account of that necessity. Since it seems an appeal to laws cannot meet this explanatory burden for the Russellian Monist, I think we should remain skeptical whether or not such a response works. Metaphysical continuity, therefore, cannot be saved, either by attempting to identify *physical_r* with *physical_i* or by trying to put both of these properties under the same metaphysical kind. Thus, the challenge of meeting Generalized Modest Humean is again the challenge of giving a non-brute explanation of structure-quality supervenience.

4. Essentialism About Consciousness

As stated earlier, the Russellian Monist's commitment to Phenomenal Intrinsicity and Phenomenal Grounding leads to the challenge of explaining how qualitatively-based structural properties supervene on categorical ones.

Additionally, if we accept Generalized Modest Humean, then the truth of Brute Connection seems to be a serious theoretical flaw of Russellian Monism. And as I've argued, it seems the Russellian Monist cannot overcome Brute Connection by attempting to establish metaphysical continuity between *physical_r* and *physical_i* properties. In light of this reasoning, I think the Russellian Monist should ultimately accept that the intrinsic phenomenal properties of matter are metaphysically discontinuous with the qualitatively-based structural properties they ground.

However, I do not think this means we must either give up Russellian Monism or structure-quality supervenience. Note that Generalized Modest Humean only counts against Russellian Monism insofar as we accept *brute* connection. So instead of trying to deny metaphysical discontinuity, the Russellian Monist should instead attempt to provide a non-brute account of structure-quality supervenience. And I think it can do precisely this by appealing to essentialism about the mind.

To begin, drawing from Leary (2017), we must first introduce the notion of an autonomous fact. As she puts it, autonomous facts "are neither grounded nor fundamental, but simply not the sorts of facts that can, in principle, have a metaphysical explanation." An autonomous fact, therefore, is a fact in which a demand for a metaphysical explanation is a category mistake. To draw an analogy, consider mathematical facts and causal explanations: $5 + 7 = 12$ has no cause due to the fact that it is just not the sort of fact that can in principle be caused. However, note that it would be ad hoc to simply stipulate that

the supervenience of structural properties as postulated by physics on intrinsic, phenomenal properties is itself an autonomous fact, since modal connections seem like eligible candidates for metaphysical explanation. On the other hand, I think there are good, independent reasons to think essence facts are autonomous facts.⁹ Essence facts, as I will use the term, are just facts about what something *is*, in its core aspects. The upshot of accepting essence facts is that they provide the basic structure which makes metaphysical explanation possible without also being the kinds of facts which require further metaphysical explanation. Consider the following grounding claim: The spatial configuration of my face fully grounds the fact that I am smiling. On the essentialist picture, a natural candidate to explain this grounding claim is that the spatial configuration of my face is just *what it is* to be smiling; it is part of the essence of a human smile to have their face spatially configured in such a way. And intuitively, this essentialist fact is just not the sort of fact we can ask for further metaphysical explanation.

So while Generalized Modest Humean would prohibit a brute fact that ruled out the free combination of discontinuous properties across modal space, the Russellian Monist could bypass this constraint by accepting that it is part of the essence of qualitatively-based structural properties, the types of properties invoked in physical explanations, to be phenomenal. Essentialism, therefore, provides a kind of ontological glue that intelligibly explains the connection between qualitatively-based structural properties and its categorical grounds without needing further explanation itself. And in doing so, the Russellian Monist gains a variety of theoretical virtues. Recall the primary issue facing the Russellian Monist: if the phenomenal qualities that constitute the intrinsic nature of the physical world are ontologically discontinuous from the structural properties as described by physics, then how is it that those latter properties are metaphysically necessitated by the former ones?

Essentialism provides exactly this link. It says that structure is simply the natural expression or outward manifestation of quality's essence; structure arises *because of what quality is*. Thus, instead of accepting a brute connection between structure and quality, essentialism allows for structure to be something that intelligibly emerges from quality. And without essentialism, it seems to me that there could be no way for the Russellian Monist to explain structure-quality supervenience without an appeal to brute identity or primitive law. But clearly, brute identity is explanatorily empty if it simply asserts sameness without giving us an explanation as to why seemingly distinct properties are the same. And appealing to laws does no favors for the Russellian Monist either; unless laws are metaphysically explained and necessitated by the essence of properties involved, they just become second-order brute facts. Furthermore, essentialism respects the asymmetry of the grounding intuition. Intuitively, it seems that quality grounds structure while the reverse does not hold. Under the essentialist picture, we should expect that the metaphysical direction of explanation to be constrained in this way, going from quality to structure rather than the other way around.

This view strikes me as theoretically attractive. Furthermore, an essentialist account of the mind is arguably entailed by the phenomenal powers view, which is detailed out by Mørch (2020):

“The phenomenal powers view is the view that phenomenal properties (i.e. properties which characterize what it is like to be in conscious states) have non-Humean causal powers—which is to say that they metaphysically necessitate their effects—in virtue of how they feel, i.e. in virtue of their phenomenal

⁹ See Fine (1994), Dasgupta (2014)

character, as opposed to in virtue of entering into contingent regularities, as per Humean or Lewisian regularity theory, or being constrained by external governing laws, as per Armstrongian realism about laws.”

On Mørch’s account of the phenomenal powers view, it is not the case that there is some phenomenal property, P , and some external law, $L(P \rightarrow S)$, that links it with some structural property. Rather, it is that P metaphysically necessitates S in virtue of its phenomenal nature. Thus, it is not the case that some law is doing the explanatory work of connecting quality with structure; it is the essence of P itself. So while Mørch does not explicitly label her view as committed to essentialism about the mind, in saying that the causal profile of some phenomenal property is derived from how it intrinsically is rather than from some accidental means, she is practically just describing what essentialism is: that both the modal and causal roles of some property are grounded in its essence.

Note the importance of the reality of mental causation here. An acceptance of essentialism about the mind without also accepting and explaining some phenomenal causal efficacy view appears explanatorily incomplete. It seems difficult to imagine how we could have intrinsic phenomenal properties whose qualitative essences somehow entail structural behavior if the intrinsic properties are themselves not causally active. Moreover, this seems to lead essentialist Russellian Monism into epiphenomenalism. If quality is causally inefficacious, then structural behavior is ungrounded, and we are back to the explanatory problem of how structure arises from quality. So, if we deny phenomenal causal efficacy, we cannot say that qualities have genuine causal power, and thus we cannot explain the emergence of structure.

On the other hand, an acceptance of some form of phenomenal causal efficacy without also accepting essentialist Russellian Monism appears arbitrary and threatens to lead to brute laws again. If we accept the existence of some form of psychophysical laws, perhaps supplemented with a form of property dualism, we are led to the claim that a phenomenal property P can cause a structural property S , but without metaphysical necessity; this causal relation holds only because the laws say so.

Yet surely this just amounts to saying P just so happens to produce S just because it does. This seems like an unacceptable explanation to me. But now we’re back to the very issue the Russellian Monist wanted to avoid at the beginning: brute correlation or nomological grounding without metaphysical explanation. So it seems that phenomenal causal efficacy needs essentialism if it does not want to render the causal efficacy of intrinsic phenomenal properties arbitrary and inexplicable.

By embracing both essentialism and phenomenal powers, the Russellian Monist can say that the intrinsic phenomenal nature of matter is neither inert nor is it brutally linked to structure. Instead, it is *essentially such* as to give rise to the structural-relational properties we observe in virtue of what it is and because of what it does. The phenomenal powers view, in order to have explanatory strength, must therefore include essentialism if it wants to avoid a collapse into brute identity or law.

5. The Essentialist Modal Challenge

There is, however, nevertheless an issue with this essentialist approach in that it fails to sharply distinguish between metaphysical and epistemological questions. To begin, consider some individual, John, who (understandably) loves the sound of shoegaze music. Now, in order to see the contrast between metaphysical and epistemological questions, we can screen off the relevant epistemological issues by stipulating that an infallible oracle has told us it is part of John's essence that he loves shoegaze music. While seemingly mysterious why auditory preferences would be part of someone's essence, we should nevertheless accept that this fact does not call out for further explanation and is thus on the explanatory floor of metaphysics. On the other hand, imagine that in trying to give a metaphysical explanation of why John loves shoegaze music so much, we say that it is simply part of his essence to have such an auditory preference. While this essentialist claim would fully and autonomously explain why John loves shoegaze music so much, that in itself gives us no reason to actually accept said essentialist claim. This is because there is simply no good reason for thinking that the essences of persons include their auditory preferences. With this in mind, let us utilize a revised version of Generalized Modest Humean:

Modest Humean-Essentialist: It counts significantly against a theory if it posits an unexplained essential connection among discontinuous properties.

Note that Modest Humean-Essentialist is not a thesis about metaphysics, like Hume's Dictum is. Instead, it is a thesis about the epistemology of metaphysics; it concerns itself with what counts against accepting a theory. It is important to clarify that Modest Humean-Essentialist does not in itself deny that there are autonomous essence facts that have the properties I've outlined above. But it does place a constraint on which facts we should accept as part of a metaphysical theory. Remember, Generalized Modest Humean was motivated by the concern that there is something mysterious about modal connections between discontinuous properties. But essence is an especially close, intimate modal relation: the essence of some entity is just what the entity's nature is. So it is especially mysterious how there could be some property which is of a radically different metaphysical kind from the constituents of its nature.

Note that in all the paradigm cases used to motivate an essentialist framework, the sorts of essence facts posited are those that link properties that are *metaphysical continuous*. In fact, we should think of essence facts as those which illuminate this continuity rather than facts that allegedly explain how there can be necessary connections between discontinuous properties. Consider the following examples of appeals to essence facts for metaphysical explanation. First, consider the plausible claim that it is part of the essence of water to be two hydrogen ions and one oxygen ion fused in some characteristic way. Because this is just what water essentially is, it seems plausible to say that water is nothing over and above its essence of two hydrogen and one oxygen ion fused in some characteristic way. Paradigm essentialist explanations like this serve to *highlight* metaphysical continuities rather than to explain how there can be necessary connections between discontinuous properties. And this is what makes essential facts autonomous: if we accept that two hydrogen and one oxygen ion fused in some characteristic way is just what it is to be water, then there is nothing left to be explained. However, now consider the claim that it is part of the essence of red that $5 + 7 = 12$. Since it is necessarily true that $5 + 7 = 12$, this claim is modally adequate: there can be no possible world in which something is red but $5 + 7 \neq 12$ simply because there are no possible worlds in which $5 + 7 \neq 12$. So while this essence claim doesn't entail any metaphysical impossibilities, it still seems incredibly hard to stomach. And the most intuitive reason for

why this claim seems absurd is because colors and mathematical properties are metaphysically discontinuous, and making one the essence of the other just makes no sense.

The conclusion to draw from these examples is this: it remains an open possibility that a complete account of the metaphysical explanation for some phenomena will inevitably invoke autonomous essence facts at its foundation. However, this mere possibility does not thereby lend the Russellian Monist a license to simply posit such essences to explain the supervenience relation between structure and quality. All plausible essentialist claims must be constrained by Modest Humean-Essentialist, and without meeting the metaphysical continuity condition between structure and quality, this move is therefore unavailable to the Russellian Monist. It thus remains an open challenge how structure supervenes on quality under the Russellian Monist picture, and without a plausible metaphysical explanation as to how this can be the case, I take Russellian Monism to be an unsuccessful theory of the mind.

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